

UNDERSTATE

1. Passage anchor

> “The pen was **understated**, but it spoke volumes.”

Passage meaning

understated = deliberately simple, restrained, and not showy or attention-seeking
低調的；含蓄的；不張揚的

Here, the fountain pen looks elegant and meaningful without being flashy.

Practice

1. The design was simple and **understated**.

這個設計簡單而**低調**。

2. She prefers **understated** jewelry.

她比較喜歡**不張揚的**首飾。

Core meanings of UNDERSTATE

2. understate — describe something as less important, serious, large, etc. than it really is

= present something as smaller, weaker, less serious, or less important than the reality

輕描淡寫；低估；說得比實際輕

Examples

1. The report **understates** the seriousness of the problem.

報告**低估了**問題的嚴重性。

2. To say the task was difficult would **understate** the challenge.

說這項任務很困難，其實仍然是**輕描淡寫**。

This is the core verb sense.

3. understate the importance / extent / scale

= make importance, size, degree, or seriousness seem smaller than it is

低估重要性 / 程度 / 規模

Examples

1. We should not ****understate the importance**** of trust.
我們不應****低估信任的重要性****。
2. The figures may ****understate the true scale**** of the problem.
這些數字可能****低估了問題的實際規模****。

Deliberately restrained expression

4. understate — express something with deliberate restraint

= say something in a restrained way rather than dramatically or emotionally
****含蓄表達；淡化****

Examples

1. He tends to ****understate his achievements****.
他往往會****淡化自己的成就****。
2. She ****understated her disappointment****.
她很****含蓄地表達了失望****。

Adjective: understated

5. understated — restrained and not showy

= attractive or effective because it is simple, subtle, and not exaggerated
****低調的；含蓄的；不張揚的****

This is the exact passage sense.

Examples

1. The room has an ****understated elegance****.
房間有一種****低調的優雅****。
2. He wore an ****understated suit****.
他穿了一套****低調雅緻的西裝****。

6. understated style / design

= style or design that avoids excessive decoration or display

****低調風格；簡約含蓄的設計****

Examples

1. The watch has an ****understated design****.

這隻手錶採用****低調設計****。

2. I like the brand's ****understated style****.

我喜歡這個品牌的****低調風格****。

Noun: understatement

7. understatement — statement that makes something seem less important/serious

= way of describing something as weaker, smaller, or less serious than it really is

****輕描淡寫；保守說法****

Examples

1. Calling the storm “bad” would be an ****understatement****.

把那場暴風雨說成只是「很糟」簡直是****輕描淡寫****。

2. Saying she was surprised is an ****understatement****.

說她只是驚訝，實在是****說得太輕了****。

8. a bit of an understatement

= something said is much weaker than the reality

****有點說輕了；其實遠不止如此****

Examples

1. “Busy” is a ****bit of an understatement****.

說「忙」其實****有點太輕描淡寫****。

2. Calling the exam difficult is ****a bit of an understatement****.

說那場考試困難，實在是****說得太輕了****。

Rhetorical device

9. understatement — rhetorical style

= deliberate use of mild language to create emphasis, irony, or humor

****含蓄修辭；反襯式輕描淡寫****

Examples

1. British humor often uses ****understatement****.

英式幽默常使用****含蓄式輕描淡寫****。

2. The sentence works through deliberate ****understatement****.

這句話透過刻意的****輕描淡寫修辭****產生效果。

Related forms

10. understatedly

= in an understated way

****低調地；含蓄地****

Examples

1. The room was ****understatedly elegant****.

房間****低調而優雅****。

2. She dressed ****understatedly**** for the event.

她為活動穿得很****低調****。

Less common than simply using ****understated****.

High-value expressions

11. to understate the case

= describe something in terms that are weaker than the reality

****把事情說輕了；低估實情****

Examples

1. To say he was disappointed would **understate the case**.

說他只是失望，其實是**把事情說輕了**。

2. "Serious" would **understate the case**.

用「嚴重」來形容其實仍然**低估了實情**。

12. that's an understatement

= what was just said is far milder than the reality

這說得太輕了；何止如此

Examples

1. "The trip was tiring." "That's an **understatement**."

「這趟旅程很累。」 「這簡直**說得太輕了**。」

2. "He was upset." "That's an **understatement**."

「他很不高興。」 「何止不高興，這真是**輕描淡寫**。」

Key contrasts

13. understate vs underestimate

understate

= express or describe something as less than it really is

說得太輕；淡化

underestimate

= judge the amount, difficulty, ability, etc. as lower than it really is

低估

Compare:

> She **understated** the problem in her report.

> 她在報告中把問題**說輕了**。

> She **underestimated** the problem.

> 她**低估了**問題本身。

The first is about **expression**; the second is about **judgment**.

14. understate vs downplay

****downplay****

= deliberately make something seem less important

****淡化；低調處理****

****understate****

= express something in milder or smaller terms than reality

They overlap strongly, but ****downplay**** often implies conscious strategic minimization.

15. understated vs simple

****simple****

= not complicated or elaborate

****簡單的****

****understated****

= intentionally restrained and non-showy, often with positive aesthetic value

****低調含蓄的****

Compare:

> a simple pen

> 一支簡單的筆

> an understated pen

> 一支低調雅緻、不張揚的筆

16. understated vs plain

****plain****

= simple and without decoration; can suggest ordinary or unattractive

****樸素的；普通的****

****understated****

= restrained in a tasteful, refined way

****低調雅緻的****

So ****understated**** is usually more positive.

17. understated vs flashy

This is the key passage contrast.

****understated****

= restrained, tasteful, subtle

****低調的；含蓄的****

****flashy****

= bright, showy, attention-seeking

****張揚的；花巧的****

The pen is deliberately described as ****understated**** because its value lies in subtlety rather than spectacle.

18. understated vs subtle

****subtle****

= not obvious; delicate or difficult to notice

****細微的；含蓄的****

****understated****

= deliberately restrained and not exaggerated

****低調的；克制的****

They overlap, especially in design and style.

Meaning map

The central idea of ****understate**** is:

****present something as less strong, large, serious, important, or noticeable than it really is****

From this develop:

Verb

understate a problem

→ ****把問題說輕了****

Achievement

understate your success

→ **淡化自己的成就**

Noun

understatement

→ **輕描淡寫**

Rhetorical style

understatement

→ **刻意含蓄修辭**

The adjective **understated** develops aesthetically:

Style/design

understated elegance

→ **低調優雅**

Passage

understated pen

→ **低調、不張揚、簡約雅緻的鋼筆**

MCQ-ready master list

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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understate — reduce in expression	把某事的嚴重性、重要性、程度等說得比實際更低；輕描淡寫
understate importance/scale	把重要性、規模或程度說得太小；低估 / 淡化
understate achievements/feelings	刻意含蓄地表達自己的成就、感受等
understated — style/design	不張揚、不誇張而顯得有品味；低調的 / 含蓄的
understated elegance	不靠華麗裝飾，而以簡約克制呈現的低調優雅
understatement — statement	把實情說得比實際更輕、更小的說法
understatement — rhetorical device	刻意用較輕的語氣表達，以產生強調、幽默或反諷效果
a bit of an understatement	某說法明顯比真實情況輕很多；有點說輕了
that's an understatement	剛才的說法遠不足以形容實情；這說得太輕了
to understate the case	把事情實際程度說得太輕 / 低估實情

| **understatedly** | 以低調、含蓄、不誇張的方式 |

Passage recap

> “The pen was **understated**, but it spoke volumes.”

Here:

understated = simple, restrained, tasteful, and not designed to attract attention loudly

Best Traditional Chinese:

* **低調的**

* **含蓄的**

* **不張揚的**

* contextually: **簡約雅緻的**

Natural contextual translation:

這支筆很低調，但它所傳達的意思卻很多。

Passage MCQ-ready meaning

understated

= deliberately restrained and not showy, often in an attractive or tasteful way

低調的；含蓄的；不張揚的

The key contrast is:

> **understated**

> → 不搶眼，但有品味、有質感

versus:

> **flashy**

> → 很搶眼、張揚、炫目

That contrast is central to the passage: the pen’s meaning comes from its **quiet personal significance**, not from being visually extravagant.